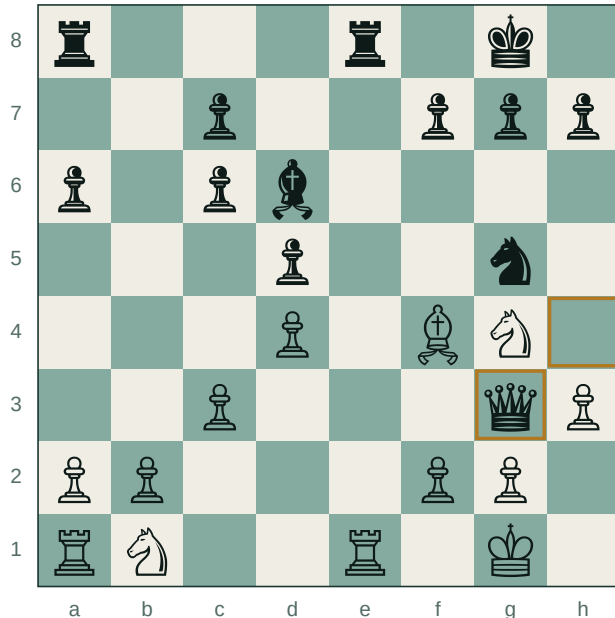


Intermediate moves: White, move 20

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 19...Qxg3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20. Rxe8+ Rxe8 21. fxg3 Bxf4 22. gxf4

20.Rxe8+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. From e8 it attacks king on g8 and rook on a8. Recorded reply: **20...Rxe8**.

21.fxg3 The pawn captures the queen on g3. Recorded reply: **21...Bxf4**.

22.gxf4 The pawn captures the bishop on f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -6 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: knight on g5 and queen on g3. Check for tactical protection.